Heaven Under Siege

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October 8, 2026

Prologue

Before the stars were counted, there was a rebellion, and it was short. One who had been the brightest of the morning stars stood before the Throne and asked whether the power that cannot be questioned can still be called just. A third of Heaven followed him. The Throne did not answer in words. When the light settled, the rebels were falling, and they fell for a long time. Then the abyss closed around them.

Then there was a garden, Eden, around the Throne. In the middle of the garden there was a tree. Creatures of clay dwelt in the garden. They looked at the tree's fruit and wanted not the sweetness but the knowing. For that, they were driven out, banished to dirt. The gate of Eden was sealed with fire.

The fire went out a long time ago. No one on this side of the gate noticed when.

Part I

The eastern gate was the quietest post of Heaven, which was why Samael had always liked it. Nothing had come to the eastern gate for longer than there had been a way to measure time. Now the dark beyond the battlements was full of lights.

"Count them again," said Samael.

"I stopped counting," said Raziel. "That was when they were still numbers."

They stood side by side on the rampart, two figures of pale light against a sky that never needed a sun. Below them the gate of Eden stood closed, tall as mountains. Its golden decoration had worn smooth with the passing of ages. Beyond it, the lights kept arriving, but they were not stars. Stars do not hold formation.

"Word has gone to the Throne?" said Raziel.

"Three times."

"And?..."

Samael was quiet. Far behind them, deep in Heaven, the Seraphim were singing *Holy.* They had been singing since the day star of the morning fell to the abyss. It was the kind of sound you stop hearing, until you listen for the pause.

"Nothing. We hold the gate. That is the instruction."

"That is the absence of an instruction."

"In Heaven those are the same thing," said Samael, almost laughing.

The lights drew nearer by degrees, patient, like a tide that knows it has all the time there is.

"Do you remember the day we closed Eden?" said Samael.

"I remember the day we closed it behind them," said Raziel, his voice careful. "I remember the sword and the fire. I remember her face. The Woman. Everyone says she wept."

"She did weep," said Samael.

"She did not. I was close enough to see. She looked back at the garden. She seemed to be memorizing it."

"She was defiant."

"She was learning, Samael. It was the only thing she knew how to do by then. It was the only thing He had ever given her, and then He punished her for it."

Samael's light brightened.

"He gave them one law. One. Of all the garden, a single tree, and a single command."

"And He planted the tree in the middle of the garden."

"A boundary that cannot be crossed is not a boundary. It is a wall. He wanted them to choose. Without rules there is no order."

"Then He cannot punish the choosing," said Raziel softly.

"He did not punish the choosing. He punished the reason. A choice without consequences is not a choice."

Raziel turned toward his companion. "They did not eat out of hunger. They ate because they wanted to understand."

"And what kind of understanding is that? Show me the knowledge a creature can hold that does not, sooner or later, end here. On top of a wall, counting ships."

Raziel turned back toward the wall of lights and gazed past the battlements. For a long while, the two of them stayed quiet.

Part II

"What did he say?" said Raziel. "When he fell, you were closer than I was."

"The Adversary said he would never kneel again."

"This is not what I heard," Raziel whispered.

"Then what did you hear?"

"I heard him say, 'Ask Him why.' He was not boasting, Samael. He was asking someone to ask."

"No one asked."

"No. No one did."

The silence between them had weight. Below, in the dark, a single ship detached from the formation and drifted forward. It was larger than the others, the color of old iron dug up from dirt.

"There are stories," said Raziel. "About what happened down there."

"Rumors."

"Gabriel, who came back from a scouting flight, said that when the first of them climbed down to him, Lucifer laughed. Creatures of mud, he called them. Fallen children of a tyrant's mistake. The brightest of the morning stars would not even look at the man."

"Then what changed?"

"The man asked him what falling felt like," said Raziel, and his voice dropped. "Not how to climb out. Not how to take revenge. What it felt like. And the story says that was the question that undid him, because no one in Heaven had ever asked him that."

Samael gazed at the approaching ship for a long moment.

"So he pitied them."

"So he recognized them."

"And the traitor armed them." Samael's hate burned bright, his sword dripping poison.

"All he ever gave them was fire. They named the stars in Heaven, and learned the way of numbers, and how the light bends around mass. The long road out of the dirt."

"A thousand suns," Samael whispered. "They hold a thousand suns, and they were clay."

"They were clay that asked questions."

Part III

The iron ship came to rest just beyond the range of the wall's defenses, as if it knew exactly where that range ended. Along its flank, a pale light kindled and held steady.

"They found the gate," said Samael. "Nothing could find the gate. It was hidden from every eye that was not ours."

"They found it the way they find anything. They kept asking, and nobody ever told them to stop."

"Someone did once," said Samael, smirking.

"Yes. I suppose He did," whispered Raziel.

Samael gripped the stone of the rampart, and for the first time in his existence the stone seemed to give a little under his hand. "Do you know what frightens me? Not that they will break the gate. They could. I think they could. It is that they might not. That they might stop at the threshold and ask to be let in, and I will not know what to say." His light flickered.

"We could say what we were told," said Raziel softly.

"We were not told anything." His voice cracked on it. "We were told to hold the gate. That is all we have ever been told. Was it that He trusted us to understand why, or that He never thought we would need to?"

Raziel turned to his old friend and searched his face for something. "Then we are both in trouble."

"We might be the only ones in Heaven who have noticed." His face was blank.

"Or we might be the only ones who still can."

Behind them, the singing faltered. Neither angel turned to see. Then a voice came across the dark. It was not loud. It

was thin, strained by distance and the machinery that carried it. A human voice from a human throat. And it spoke in the oldest tongue, the one the first two had been taught in the garden, which no one on that side of the gate had heard spoken in ages. It said a single sentence.

Samael's hand moved to the horn at his belt, the long white horn that had not been sounded since the day the rebels fell. "You heard it. They demand entry."

"They do not demand anything. They are asking."

"It was a command," said Samael in his iron voice.

"It was a question."

"I know what I heard."

Raziel looked at his friend's face. It was bright with wrath. "So do it."

The iron ship held its pale light steady. The ranks of the armada waited, countless and still. Behind the wall, the great silence of the Throne pressed outward, neither forbidding nor permitting, and for the first time neither angel could say whether that was patience or absence.

Samael's fist closed around the horn. Raziel rested his hand on the key to the gate. Neither could have said afterward which of them moved first, or whether either had. On the far side of the gate, someone was waiting to be answered.

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